

Google — Project Aristotle: What Actually Makes a High-Performing Team?

Key Facts

Company	Google LLC (Alphabet Inc.)
Industry	Technology / Search and Advertising
Founded	1998 — Larry Page and Sergey Brin
Headquarters	Mountain View, California, USA
Key Figures	Employees: 180,000+ 180 teams studied Two years of research
Case Focus	Human Resources — psychological safety and team effectiveness

Executive Summary

In 2012, Google launched "Project Aristotle" — an ambitious study analyzing 180 internal teams over two years, to answer a single question: "What makes some teams high-performing while other teams with the same talent struggle?" The initial hypothesis was that the best teams are those that "assemble stars" — the smartest and most experienced individuals. But the data proved the exact opposite.

After analyzing hundreds of variables — education, personality, skills, gender, age, shared hobbies, office locations — the researchers reached a striking conclusion: who is on the team matters far less than how they interact together. One factor stood above all others as the strongest indicator of team effectiveness: psychological safety.

Researcher Amy Edmondson of Harvard University defined it as "the shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking." In teams with high psychological safety, members feel comfortable asking questions, admitting mistakes, offering half-formed ideas, and disagreeing with the manager — without fear of punishment or embarrassment. In teams with low psychological safety, silence prevails. Mistakes are hidden. Bold ideas are never raised. The result: lower performance despite the same talent.

This case study reveals the five findings of Project Aristotle — psychological safety, dependability, structure and clarity, meaning, and impact — with psychological safety as the foundation of the other four. Google changed how it forms teams and trains managers based on these findings. The practical application: how any organization — from a startup to a government ministry — can build "psychologically safe" teams that deliver exceptional performance.

The Five Dynamics of Team Effectiveness

1. Psychological safety	The belief that you won't be punished for taking risks, asking questions, or admitting mistakes
2. Dependability	Knowing your teammates will deliver what they promised on time
3. Structure and clarity	Clear roles, goals, and execution plans for each member
4. Meaning	The feeling that the work matters personally to each team member
5. Impact	The belief that the team's work makes a real difference

Discussion Questions

1. Psychological Safety

- Why was psychological safety a stronger predictor of team effectiveness than any other factor — including group IQ and prior experience?
- How can a team leader build psychological safety in a competitive work environment?

2. Team Culture

- Can Project Aristotle's results be replicated in non-Western cultures?
- How do you handle a team member who destroys psychological safety for others?